

TAMIL NADU & KARNATAKA ORIGIN

Uttapam

Thick Fermented Rice Pancakes with Toppings
South India's Most Satisfying Tiffin

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Uttapam

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Uttapam

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Pancake That Was Never Meant to Be

The uttapam began as a rescue — a use for dosa batter that had fermented a little too long, too thick, or too sour to be spread into the paper-thin wafer of a classic dosa. Instead of discarding it, cooks poured the thick batter onto a hot tawa, scattered vegetables over the wet surface, and pressed them in. The result was so good it became a dish in its own right.

The name comes from the Tamil word 'uttappam' — sometimes also called 'adai' in certain regions, though adai uses a different multi-lentil batter. By the 20th century, uttapam had earned its own entry on every Udupi restaurant menu, no longer a byproduct but a first choice for those who wanted something more substantial than a dosa and more flavourful than a plain idli.

Unlike dosa, uttapam is never thin. Its thickness is the point — a dense, slightly sour centre that absorbs the juices of the toppings as it cooks, caramelising the onion and tomato directly into the batter. It is the most forgiving dish in the South Indian breakfast repertoire: the batter can be two days old, the toppings anything in the refrigerator, and the uttapam still turns out well.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Pancake That Was Never Meant to Be, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

A staple of Udupi restaurants across India — almost always listed alongside idli and dosa on tiffin menus. Commonly made at home when idli-dosa batter has over-fermented and is too sour for regular dosa — the thickness absorbs and balances the excess sourness. The onion-tomato uttapam is the most popular version; cheese uttapam and paneer uttapam are modern restaurant additions. In Karnataka it is sometimes served as an evening tiffin (snack) as well as breakfast, unlike the more strictly morning-focused idli or vada.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	Overnight	25m	4 (8 uttapams)	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	FERMENT TIME	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Heavy cast iron tawa or non-stick griddle (minimum 25 cm diameter)
- Ladle (½ cup / 120 ml capacity)
- Flat spatula for flipping
- Small bowls for organising toppings before cooking
- Lid or dome cover (optional, for steaming the top)

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Fermented batter keeps refrigerated for 3–4 days; the batter improves in flavour over the first 2 days. Cooked uttapam does not store well — it loses its crisp bottom and soft interior within 20 minutes. Make fresh and serve immediately. The topping mixture (chopped onion, tomato, chilli, coriander) can be prepared and refrigerated up to 2 hours ahead.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the uttapam

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Idli / dosa batter (fermented)	2 cups	480 ml	2 katori
Onion, finely chopped	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Tomato, finely chopped	1 medium	80 g	1 medium
Green chillies, finely chopped	2	2	2
Fresh coriander, chopped	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp
Fresh ginger, grated	½ tsp	2 g	½ chammach
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste
Oil or ghee (for cooking)	1–2 tsp per uttapam	5–10 ml	1–2 chammach

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

The batter is the foundation — use the same rice and urad dal batter as for idli and dosa (ideally 24–48 hours fermented for best flavour). For toppings, any combination of finely chopped vegetables works: capsicum, carrot, sweetcorn, spring onion. The onion and tomato combination is the classic; never skip the onion, as it caramelises and provides moisture to the cooking batter. Ghee gives a richer flavour than oil but is optional.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing Batter & Toppings

01 PREPARE THE TOPPING MIX

Combine the finely chopped onion, tomato, green chillies, coriander, and grated ginger in a bowl. Mix gently. This is scattered over the uttapam immediately after pouring the batter, before the surface sets.

> **Chef tip.** Chop the onion and tomato very finely — large chunks sit on top rather than embedding into the batter. Squeeze the tomato pieces lightly in a clean cloth if they are very watery.

02 CHECK BATTER CONSISTENCY

The batter for uttapam should be slightly thicker than for dosa — it should fall from the ladle in a thick ribbon, not flow like water. If the batter is too thin, it spreads too far and becomes difficult to keep thick. If needed, rest the batter (uncovered) at room temperature for 30 minutes to thicken slightly.

03 HEAT THE TAWA

Place a cast iron tawa or non-stick griddle over medium-high heat. Allow it to heat for 2–3 minutes until a drop of water sizzles immediately on contact. Reduce to medium heat before pouring the batter.

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Preparing Batter & Toppings, continued



COOKING CHECKPOINT

A properly heated tawa is the single most important factor in a well-cooked uttapam. Test by flicking a few drops of water — they should sizzle and evaporate within 2 seconds. Too cold: batter sticks and spreads unevenly. Too hot: the base burns before the top sets.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Uttapam

04 POUR AND KEEP THICK

Drizzle a few drops of oil over the tawa. Pour a generous ladleful (about ½ cup) of batter onto the centre of the tawa. Using the back of the ladle, spread it gently into a circle about 15 cm wide and 1 cm thick — much thicker than dosa. Do not spread too thin.

05 ADD TOPPINGS IMMEDIATELY

While the batter is still completely wet on top, scatter a generous handful of the onion-tomato-chilli mixture evenly over the surface. Press the toppings lightly into the wet batter with the back of a spoon or spatula so they adhere.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Uttapam, continued



Chef tip. Add the toppings while the batter is completely raw on top — this embeds them into the uttapam. If you wait until the surface starts to set, the toppings simply sit on top and fall off when you flip.

06 COOK UNTIL SET, THEN FLIP

Cook uncovered over medium heat for 3–4 minutes until the edges look cooked, the bottom is golden brown, and the surface has turned mostly matte (no more raw-wet shine). Drizzle a teaspoon of oil around the edges. Slide the spatula fully under the uttapam and flip in one confident move.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Uttapam, continued

07 COOK THE TOPPING SIDE

Cook for 2–3 minutes on the topping side until the onion has caramelised slightly and the tomato has cooked into the batter. The uttapam is done when both sides are golden and the uttapam feels firm but slightly springy when pressed. Serve immediately.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

The most common mistake is flipping too early. Wait until the entire surface has turned matte and the edges have clearly set — a premature flip tears the uttapam and spills the toppings. Patience of 3–4 minutes is always rewarded.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Classic Tiffin Style

- Served with coconut chutney and a bowl of sambar for dipping — the same pairing as idli.
- A small knob of butter on top of a freshly cooked uttapam is a popular restaurant addition.

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How to serve, continued

With Multiple Chutneys

- Uttapam pairs well with a trio: coconut chutney, tomato chutney, and mint-coriander chutney — each provides a different contrast to the thick batter.
- A red garlic chutney (podi mixed with oil) spread inside gives an extra heat layer.

Modern Variations

- Cheese uttapam: grated processed cheese added to the toppings before flipping — melts into a golden crust on the outside.
- Mixed vegetable uttapam with finely grated carrot, capsicum, and sweetcorn is a popular children's school-day breakfast.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Tawa Temperature Management

- Keep the flame at medium throughout cooking — not high, not low. High heat burns the base before the thick interior cooks; low heat makes the uttapam absorb too much oil and turn heavy.
- A cast iron tawa retains heat better than non-stick and produces a crispier base; a non-stick tawa is more forgiving for beginners.

Batter Sourness

- A 36–48 hour old batter (slightly over-fermented) makes the best uttapam — the extra sourness is balanced by the sweetness of the caramelised onion.
- If using fresh same-day batter, add a small pinch of citric acid or a few drops of lemon juice to approximate the flavour of well-fermented batter.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Restaurant uttapams are made thicker than most home versions. Use a full ½-cup ladle and resist the urge to spread thinly — thickness is what distinguishes a proper uttapam from a dosa.

Add a tiny pinch of cumin seeds and curry leaves directly to the oiled tawa before pouring the batter for an aromatic, restaurant-quality base.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

120 kcal	3 g	20 g	3 g	1.5 g
CALORIES (PER UTTAPAM)	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with preparation method and serving size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Onion Uttapam	The most popular version; finely chopped onion alone as a topping gives a subtler, sweeter result than the onion-tomato combination.
Mixed Veg Uttapam	Finely grated carrot, chopped capsicum, sweetcorn, and spring onion — colourful, nutritious, and popular in school and office canteen menus.
Cheese Uttapam	Grated processed cheese (or mozzarella) added over the toppings before flipping; the cheese melts and crisps against the tawa — a modern restaurant favourite.
Mini Uttapam	Palm-sized uttapams (about 8 cm) cooked in batches of three — identical technique but easier to flip and more elegant for serving multiple chutneys.

My uttapam is raw in the middle even though the outside is golden – how do I fix it?

The heat was too high and the uttapam too thick at the centre. After flipping, cover with a dome lid for 1–2 minutes — the trapped steam finishes cooking the interior without further browning the outside.

The toppings keep falling off when I flip – what am I doing wrong?

The toppings were added after the surface started to set. Add them immediately while the batter is 100% wet and then press down firmly with the back of a spoon — they will embed into the batter and hold through the flip.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make uttapam with store-bought idli batter?

Yes, store-bought fermented batter works well. Reduce the salt added to the batter slightly as commercial batters often contain added salt. Allow to sit at room temperature for 30 minutes before using for the best texture.

How is uttapam different from a dosa?

Dosa is spread paper-thin and is crisp throughout. Uttapam is kept thick — at least 1 cm — and has a soft, bread-like interior with a golden crust. They use the same batter but are fundamentally different dishes in texture and eating experience.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Tawa	a flat or slightly concave Indian griddle; cast iron tawa gives the best heat distribution for uttapam.
Udupi restaurant	South Indian vegetarian restaurant style originating in Udupi, Karnataka; the canonical home of idli, dosa, and uttapam tiffin.
Tadka	spices bloomed in hot oil; sometimes added to uttapam batter or poured over the cooked surface as a final seasoning.
Over-fermented batter	batter left beyond 24–36 hours that has developed extra sourness; ideal for uttapam, less ideal for soft idli.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Uttapam

10m ACTIVE PREP	Overnight FERMENT TIME
25m COOK TIME	4 (8 uttapams) SERVINGS
Easy DIFFICULTY	

UTTAPAM

Idli / dosa batter	480 ml
Onion	100 g
Tomato	80 g
Green chillies	2
Fresh coriander	8 g
Fresh ginger	2 g
Salt	to taste
Oil or ghee	5–10 ml

METHOD

01 **Prepare the topping mix.** Combine the finely chopped onion, tomato, green chillies, coriander, and grated ginger in a bowl.

02 **Check batter consistency.** The batter for uttapam should be slightly thicker than for dosa — it should fall from the ladle in a thick ribbon, not flow like water.

03 **Heat the tawa.** Place a cast iron tawa or non-stick griddle over medium-high heat.

04 **Pour and keep thick.** Drizzle a few drops of oil over the tawa.

05 **Add toppings immediately.** While the batter is still completely wet on top, scatter a generous handful of the onion-tomato-chilli mixture evenly over the surface.

06 **Cook until set, then flip.** Cook uncovered over medium heat for 3–4 minutes until the edges look cooked, the bottom is golden brown, and the surface has turned mostly matte (no more raw-wet shine).

07 **Cook the topping side.** Cook for 2–3 minutes on the topping side until the onion has caramelised slightly and the tomato has cooked into the batter.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Idli / dosa batter	480 ml	☐ Onion	100 g
☐ Tomato	80 g	☐ Green chillies	2
☐ Fresh coriander	8 g	☐ Fresh ginger	2 g
☐ Salt	to taste	☐ Oil or ghee	5–10 ml

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